



feature

Mark the dates 28

There is a lot to look forward to next month. To find out more, flip over to

unless of course the travel website has some sort of special offer.

Bus booking can also be done online at web sites such as redbus.in and ticketvala.com. These web sites have essentially consolidated all the small tourist bus operators in the country into a single platform. So you



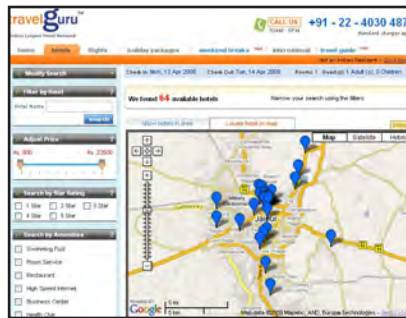
CONNECTIONS

can look at bus timings, prices and other details and simply book online. In the booking process, you can even look at the seat layout and select your boarding point. Sure, you can probably go to a Konduskar or Neeta Travels yourself but isn't this much simpler? Parijat Kaushik, an avid traveller and weekend getaway enthusiast said, "I found the experience with both these web sites quite satisfying. They are quick to respond to web queries and there is always the help line number where you can talk to customer service."

Railtourism.com and travelchacha.com give you details on cab and car rentals within most cities. You can even book a car online. If you have no road transport planned for any part of your journey but want to get to your starting point (Airport, railway station), you have the option of city specific cab services such as www.merucabs.com for Mumbai, Delhi, Hyderabad and Bangalore.

Part 3: Accommodation

OK, now that you know where to go and how to get there you need to figure out your accommodation. For both domestic and international travel, people are increasingly getting comfortable with booking hotels online. However, you need to put in a fair bit of research here. Lots of hotels from all segments are well covered by web sites such as travelguru.com and makemytrip.com. You get to know indicative prices but as any experienced traveller will tell you that there is a bit of scope for bargaining. On a web site such as travelguru.com, you enter your destination, check in and check out dates, and number of people. Say your destination is Jaipur, the web site will instantly tell you it has 91 hotels registered under that location. Hitting search will give you several options. You can filter searches by which category of hotel you are looking for (5 star, 4 star, etc) and by amenities (swimming pool, internet access, etc). There is also a price slider to filter by price. For each hotel you have room descriptions



Locate hotel on maps at travelguru

and photos. Photos here are very important as you get to see the rooms and facilities. There is also a lowest average price mentioned as well as user rating. Even a one star hotel we found had 22 reviews so the user community is pretty active here. One you decide on the type of room you want, simply pay online and book.

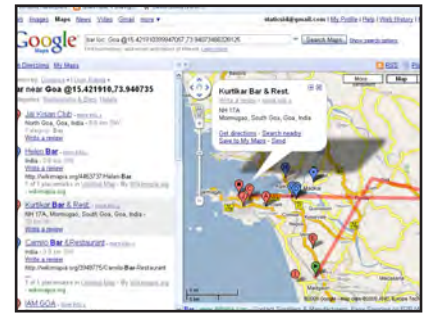
Another interesting web site is nivalink.com which boasts impressive statistics such as 1,000+ custom itineraries, a database of 3,000+ hotels / resorts, 1,00,000 individuals serviced, and over 10,000 pictures to browse. The web site describes itself as a web-assisted, research-driven customised travel solutions provider. Suppose you wish to find hotels in the Kerala backwaters, simply click the link under itineraries and accommodation options. You will be



Intl' travel specs

Communication is very important, so be sure to check out what's available at www.matrix.in. You should visit your bank's website to get information on international forex and debit card transactions.

Sure, it'll be a bit complex but visit the Indian customs and excise website at www.cbec.gov.in to get the latest information on baggage rules and other inputs on foreign travel.



Use Google maps to plot direction and hot spots

presented with a list of all available hotel options. Click on any one and you get a detailed description of facilities with pictures and also contact details. If you are looking for reservations and travel assistance for an itinerary that covers more than one destination, email [nivalink](mailto:nivalink@nivalink.com) with details and they promise they will get back to you with a model itinerary, plus suggestions and detailed cost estimates.

A peculiarity with accommodation is that the bulk of it is provided by small and medium sized enterprises. These small businesses provide unique, friendly and quaint living experiences which are much more personal. It is always difficult for travellers to source information about their properties, let alone book them and receive instant confirmation.

Another booking solution is to go to the hotel chain's web site directly. For instance, Ginger Hotels a budget hotel chain has a very comprehensive web site that lets you view, choose and book at a hotel of your choice.

But how do you make sure that you will indeed get what you are paying for? This is where reviews come in. There are exclusive hotel review web sites such as oktabebyebye.com where you can find a whole lot of user reviews. This site lets you cross check rates with other web sites such as [makemytrip](http://makemytrip.com) and [travelocity](http://travelocity.com).

Using online mapping services to plot your itinerary

Now that you are all set to take off, you probably would want to plot your itinerary on one of the online mapping services such as Yahoo! maps or Google maps. You can even print them out and carry along to help you along your journey. The My Maps service from Google allows you to overlay information such as photos, weather, and public transit maps. You can even mark the places you want to visit along the way on the map so that you don't miss out any. Featured content by Google shows you hot spots and displays distance.

By now you must surely be toying with the idea of claiming all your accrued leave. So, be your own travel agent, head out and remember that everything is just a click away. ■

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